at Qandahar was not really his own: four days after he entered the city, Humayun handed it over to Muhammad Murad Mirza, the Persian shah's infant son who was in nominal command of the Persian army that had helped Humayun defeat Askari. The Persian prince was too young to make any claims or decisions himself, but his commanders – one Budagh Khan in particular – were quite clear that the victory, and its spoils, belonged to their shah. Much like Tahmasp's hospitality, his army, too, had strings attached, and not half so finely wrought. Not only was Humayun unable to stop the Persians looting the locals, he couldn't even persuade Budagh Khan to let his harem stay in Qandahar while Humayun and his troops went on to Kabul. Such was Humayun's ignominy that he was still camped outside the city gates after having 'won' it, and was wondering if he should go to Badakhshan instead of Kabul and seek an alliance with Sulaiman, when, in a sudden stroke of luck, the Persian shah's son died.

Humayun's chieftains wanted to chase the Persians away immediately. Humayun, averse to any bloodshed that would 'look ill in the eyes of good men'[26] – like Shah Tahmasp, presumably – proposed a less aggressive approach. The chiefs prevailed: groups of them lay in ambush around the several gates of the fort and stormed it at dawn with ruthless efficiency – one gatekeeper who tried to resist had his hand cut off by a flashing sword. By noon that day, Bairam Khan was governor of Qandahar, and Budagh Khan had 'apologised for his offence' to Humayun, who reciprocated with a tactful letter for Tahmasp, assuring him that Qandahar's governor might have changed from Budagh to Bairam, but the city remained the shah's.

Finally, Humayun set off for Kabul. He left Hamida behind, but took Askari (who had tried to run away and been found hiding under a blanket in an Afghan's hut) and Khanzada Begum. Their venerable aunt was close to seventy years old and had lived a life of unusual adventure. As a young girl, she had been given as wife (and hostage) to Babur's great rival Shaibani Khan, the Uzbek king of Samarqand; in middle age, she had been among Babur's senior advisers, her husband Mahdi Khwaja had almost succeeded him to the Hindustani throne; and now, in her old age, she had preserved what little peace and goodwill she could between her brother's unhappy heirs. The mission to Qandahar, however, was her last on the family's behalf; she died on the way to Kabul.